Rosette

I don't make these very often, so I have dug out an old job that I did a few years ago because I felt the intricate shapes would offer a suitable challenge and be a good way of showing how to make the cuts cleanly.

As before, the design is marked out on the disc and the shape is blocked out with my spindle gouge and round scraper to cut the fillets on the face. The first shape that I turned was the ring which is visible from the side and face of the rosette. You will notice the pencil line on the face of the rosette, which marks the high point of the ring, the top of the hill if we were to continue the analogy from earlier, which means I need to cut down hill from each side of this line. Keeping the handle low and cutting just to one side of the tip, I gradually form the ring. The main thing to be aware of as you make this cut is that the shaving should always be coming from this point – just to the side of the tip – throughout the cut. This will maintain control of the tool and avoid a catch.

Having cut down both sides of the 'hill' from the face, I roll the tool over so the flute almost faces the work and use a light shear cut to perfect the shape. Looking at the edge of the rosette, the ring continues around and there is a small half cove flowing up to the edge. These need to be drawn out using the wing of the tool. Ensure the wing is trailing to avoid a catch. I then use a shear cut to finish off the shape. The central dome is cut in much the same way as the ring on the face of the rosette. Keeping the handle low I cut just to the left of the tip, with the bevel rubbing, and form the shape.

The cove on the face can be tricky because if the presentation is not just right, the tool can try to skid across the face of the rosette. The handle is once again low and I slice into the cove, again using the part of the edge just to the side of the tip. As with a cove on spindle work, this cove is cut down from the rim to the base of the curve. I find keeping the handle of the tool low a real help at the beginning of the cut, raising it up and swinging it to form the cove. Having a lathe with a good centre height is a real bonus as it allows this unrestricted movement without the bed bars getting in the way. It is possible to make the cut on a smaller lathe, but you will need to feel for the best presentation of the tool while maintaining control and producing a good shape. The rosette is then sanded, like the plinth, 180 to 320 grits and finished with oil to bring out the figure of the oak.

I've done all this but the grain is still rough!

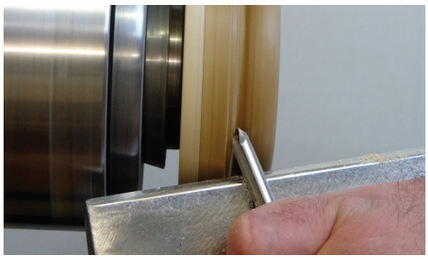
Some timbers are naturally more difficult to achieve a good finish with. Sharp tools and good presentation will get you most of the way, but sometimes the wood still doesn't want to do as it's told. I would recommend applying a coat of your chosen finish to the work. If you intend to oil the work then apply oil, likewise with lacquer, sanding sealer or wax. If in doubt then sanding sealer is a good option as this is the most compatible finish, being unlikely to interfere with your chosen final finish.

By applying a generous layer of finish, it will penetrate into those difficult areas and help to support and stiffen the offending wood fibres, allowing a freshly sharpened tool to cut them much more cleanly. In extreme circumstances you can reapply the finish before sanding to give that final bit of added support to the grain. ●

The rosette has been blocked out and here I am cutting downhill to form the ring. Notice where the shaving is coming from on the edge of the tool

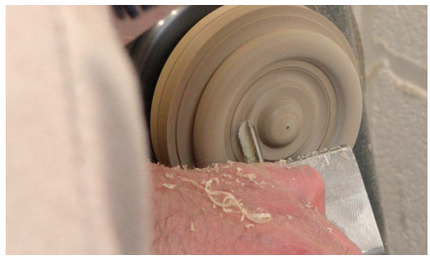
The same applies for the other side of the ring, only this time the shaving comes from the right of the tip. Notice the handle is held low throughout

I use a shear cut to refine the shape of the ring



When working on the edge of faceplate work, the shapes need to be drawn out with the trailing wing of the tool

Cutting the central dome



Cutting the cove in the face of the rosette – notice the low handle again

Sanding the rosette

The rosette, ready to oil

The complete trophy base and rosette

WT_287_27_31_RICHARD_FINDLEYbdJRmbRFSD.indd 31 06/11/2015 09:27